

Apache OpenOffice

Version 4.1

Writer Guide

Chapter 16 **Customizing Writer**

AOO Documentation Team

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Introduction

This chapter describes common customization's to AOO Writer that you may wish to do.

You can customize menus, toolbars, and keyboard shortcuts, add new menus and toolbars, and assign macros to events. However, you cannot customize context (right-click) menus.

Other customizations can be easily done with extensions installed from the OpenOffice.org website or from other providers.

Note

Customizations to menus and toolbars can be saved in a template. To do so, first save them in a document and then save the document as a template as described in Chapter 10 (Working with Templates).

Customizing Menu Content

In addition to changing the menu font (described in Chapter 2), you can add and rearrange items on the menu bar, add items to menus, and make other changes.

To customize menus:

- 1) Choose **Tools > Customize**.
- 2) On the **Customize** dialog box, go to the **Menus** tab (Figure 1).
- 3) In the Save In drop-down list, choose whether to save this changed menu for the entire Writer application, or for a selected document.
- 4) In the section **OpenOffice Writer > Menus**, select from the **Menu** drop-down list the menu that you want to customize. The list includes all the main menus as well as sub-menus, that is menus that are contained under another menu. For example, in addition to *File*, *Edit*, *View*, and so on, there is *File | Send* and *File | Templates*. The commands available for the selected menu are shown in the central part of the dialog box.
- 5) To customize the selected menu, click on the **Menu** or **Modify** buttons. You can also add commands to a menu by clicking on the **Add** button. These actions are described in the following sections. Use the up and down arrows next to the Entries list to move the selected menu item to a different position.
- 6) When you have finished making all your changes, click **OK** to save them.

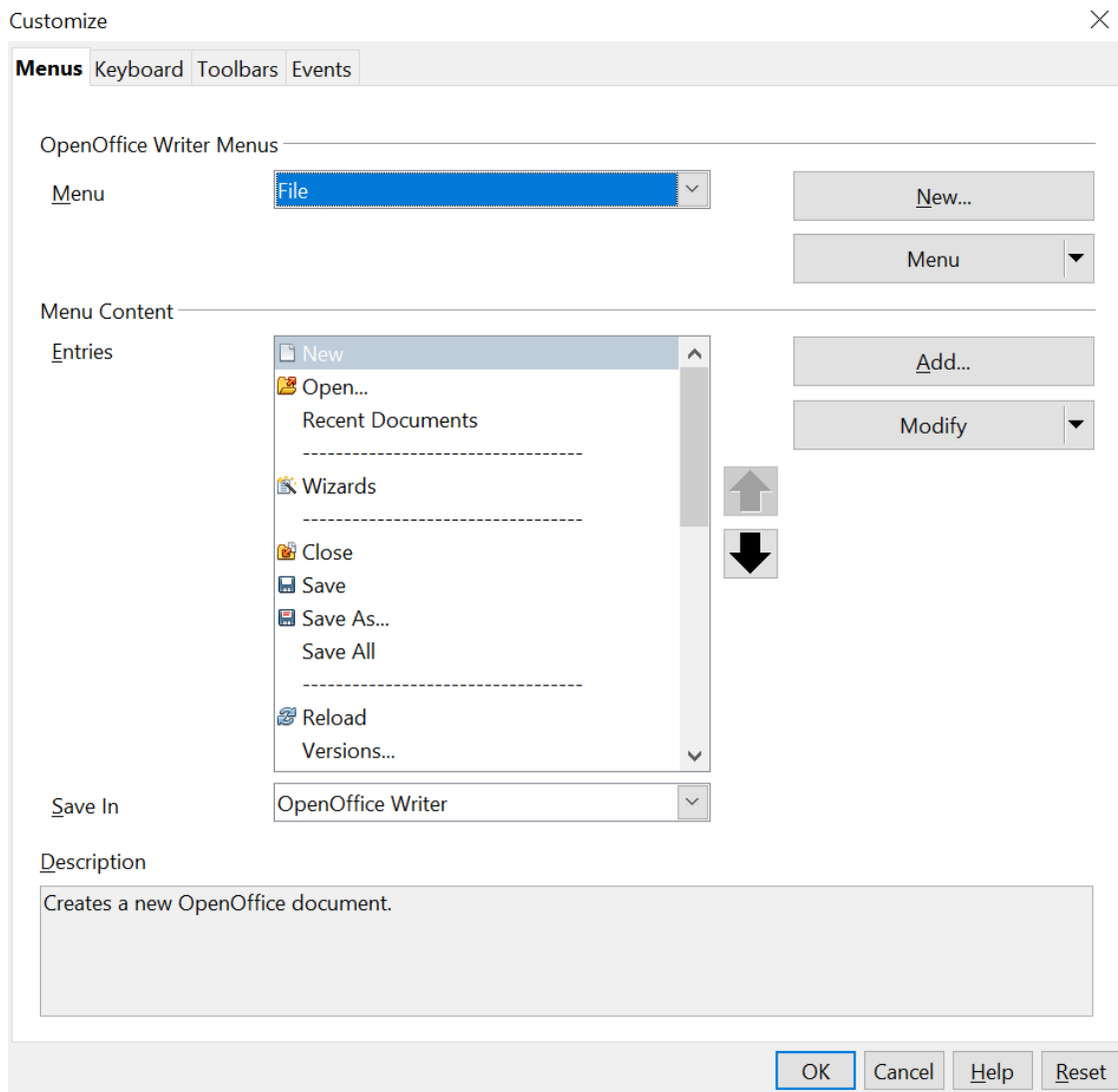


Figure 1. The Menus tab of the Customize dialog box

Creating a New Menu

In the Customize dialog box, click **New** to display the New Menu dialog box, shown in Figure 2.

- 1) Type a name for your new menu in the **Menu name** box.
- 2) Use the up and down arrow buttons to move the new menu into the required position on the menu bar.
- 3) Click **OK** to save.

The new menu now appears on the list of menus in the Customize dialog box. (It will appear on the menu bar itself after you save your customizations.)

After creating a new menu, you need to add some commands to it, as described in “Adding a Command to a Menu” on page 6.

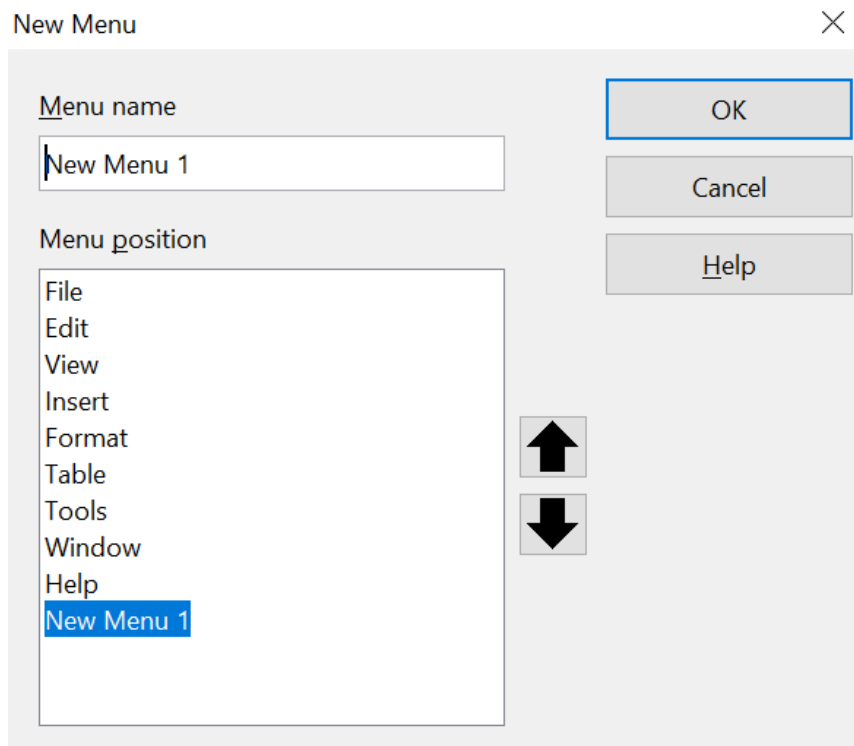


Figure 2: Adding a new menu

Modifying Existing Menus

To modify an existing menu, select it in the Menu list and click the **Menu** button to drop down a list of modifications: **Move**, **Rename**, **Delete**. Not all of these modifications can be applied to all the entries in the Menu list. For example, **Rename** and **Delete** are not available for the supplied menus.

To move a menu (such as *File*), choose **Menu > Move**. A dialog box similar to the one shown in Figure 2 (but without the **Menu name** box) opens. Use the up and down arrow buttons to move the menu into the required position.

To move submenus (such as *File | Send*), select the main menu (File) in the Menu list and then, in the Menu Content section of the dialog box, select the submenu (Send) in the Entries list and use the arrow keys to move it up or down in the sequence. Submenus are easily identified in the Entries list by a small black triangle on the right-hand side of the name.

In addition to renaming, you can specify a keyboard shortcut that allows you to select a menu command when you press *Alt*+ an underlined letter in a menu command.

- 1) Select a menu or menu entry.
- 2) Click the **Menu** button and select **Rename**.
- 3) Add a tilde (~) in front of the letter that you want to use as an accelerator. For example, to select the Save All command by pressing *Alt*+*V*, enter *Sa~ve All*.

Adding a Command to a Menu

You can add commands to the supplied menus and to menus you have created. On the Customize dialog box, select the menu in the Menu list and click the **Add** button in the Menu Content section of the dialog box.

On the Add Commands dialog box, select a category and then the command, and click **Add**. The dialog box remains open, so you can select several commands. When you

have finished adding commands, click **Close**. Back on the Customize dialog box, you can use the up and down arrow buttons to arrange the commands in your preferred sequence.

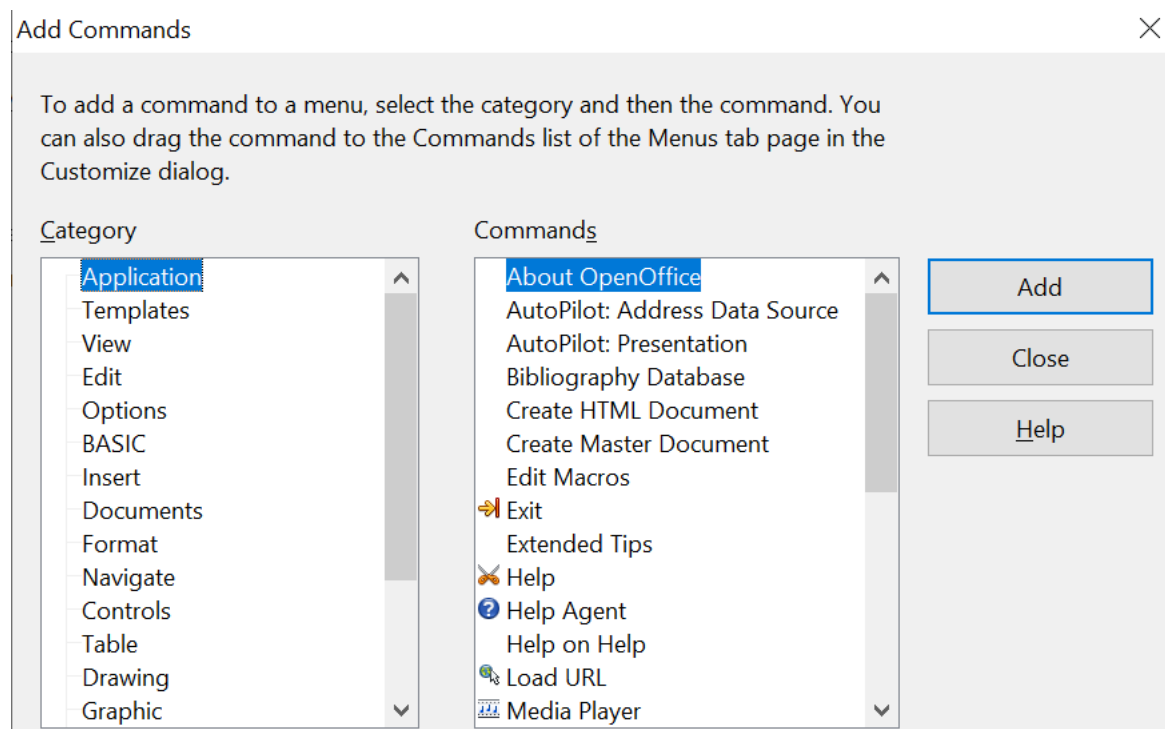


Figure 3: Adding a command to a menu

Modifying Menu Entries

In addition to changing the sequence of entries on a menu or submenu, you can add submenus, rename or delete the entries, and add group separators.

To begin, select the menu or submenu in the Menu list near the top of the Customize page, then select the entry in the Entries list under Menu Content. Click the **Modify** button and choose the required action from the drop-down list of actions.

Most of the actions should be self-explanatory. **Begin a group** adds a separator line after the highlighted entry.

Customizing Toolbars

You can customize toolbars in several ways, including choosing which icons are visible and locking the position of a docked toolbar, as described in Chapter 1 (Introducing Writer), and adding or deleting icons (commands) in the list of those available on a toolbar. You can also create new toolbars. This section describes how to create new toolbars and add or delete icons on existing ones.

To get to the toolbar customization dialog box, do any of the following:

- On the toolbar, click the arrow at the end of the toolbar and choose **Customize Toolbar**.
- Choose **View > Toolbars > Customize** from the menu bar.
- Choose **Tools > Customize** from the menu bar and go to the **Toolbars** tab.

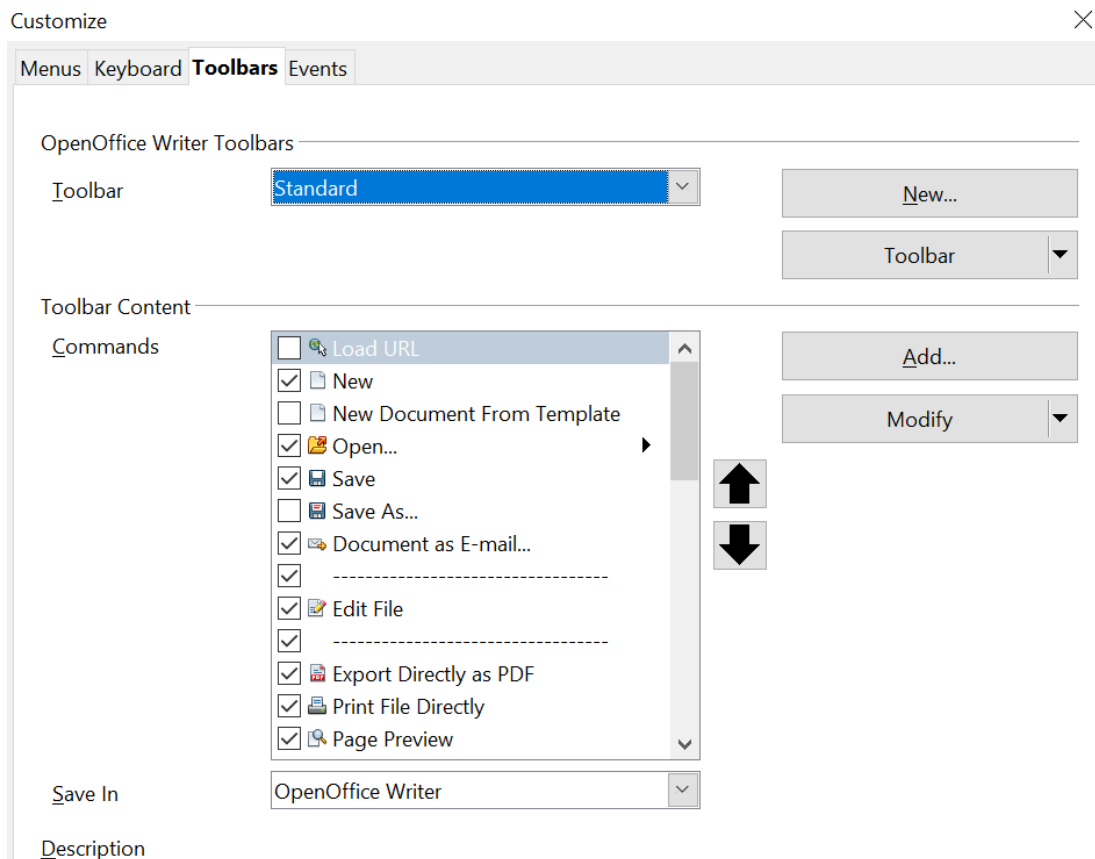


Figure 4. The Toolbars tab of the Customize dialog box

Modifying Existing Toolbars

To modify an existing toolbar:

- 1) In the Save In drop-down list, choose whether to save this changed toolbar for the application (Writer) or for a selected document.
- 2) In the section **OpenOffice Writer > Toolbars**, select from the **Toolbar** drop-down list the toolbar that you want to modify.
- 3) Click on the **Toolbar** or **Modify** buttons, and add commands to a toolbar by clicking on the **Add** button. You can also create a new toolbar by clicking on the **New** button. These actions are described in the following sections.
- 4) When you have finished making all your changes, click **OK** to save them.

Adding a Command to a Toolbar

If the list of available buttons for a toolbar does not include all the commands you'd like on that toolbar, you can add commands. And of course, when you create a new toolbar, you need to add commands to it.

- 1) On the Toolbars tab of the Customize dialog box, select the toolbar in the Toolbar list and click the **Add** button in the Toolbar Content section of the dialog box.
- 2) The Add Commands dialog box (Figure 3) is the same as for adding commands to menus. Select a category and then the command, and click **Add**. The dialog box remains open, so you can select several commands. When you have finished adding commands, click **Close**. If you insert an item which does not have an associated icon, the toolbar will display the full name of the item: the next section describes how to choose an icon for a toolbar command.

- 3) Back on the Customize dialog box, you can use the up and down arrow buttons to arrange the commands in your preferred sequence.
- 4) When you are done making changes, click **OK** to save.

Choosing Icons for Toolbar Commands

Toolbar buttons usually have icons, not words, on them, but not all the commands have associated icons.

To choose an icon for a command, select the command in the Toolbar list in the Customize dialog box, and click **Modify > Change icon**. On the Change Icon dialog box, you can scroll through the available icons, select one, and click **OK** to assign it to the command.

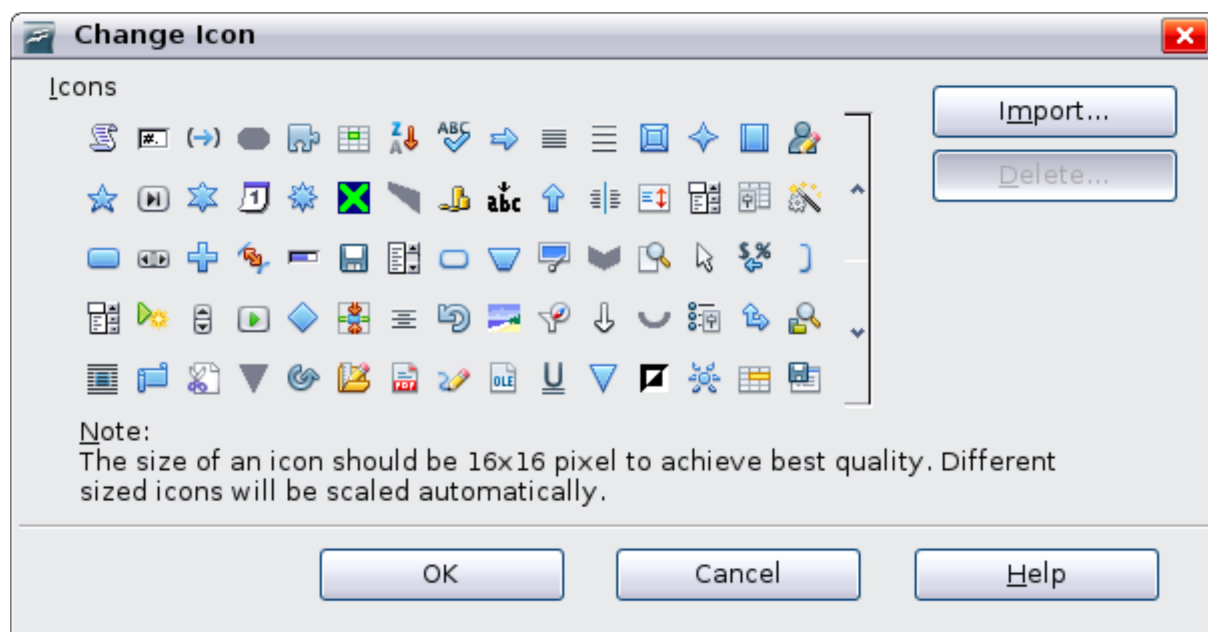


Figure 5: Change Icon dialog box

To use a custom icon, create it in a graphics program and import it by clicking the **Import** button on the Change Icon dialog box. Custom icons must be 16 x 16 or 26 x 26 pixels in size and cannot contain more than 256 colors.

Example: Adding an Insert > Cross-reference Icon to a Toolbar

You can customize OpenOffice so that a single click on an icon automatically opens the dialog for inserting a cross-reference.

- 1) Click the arrow icon at the end of the Standard toolbar. In the drop-down menu, choose **Customize Toolbar**. The Toolbars tab of the Customize dialog box appears (Figure 4). Click **Add**.
On the Add Commands dialog box (Figure 6), select *Insert* in the Category list, then select *Cross-reference* in the Commands list. Click **Add**. Now you can see the new icon in the Commands list.
- 2) In the Commands list, click the up or down arrow button to position the new icon where you want it. Click **OK** and then click **Close**. Your toolbar now has a new icon to add a cross-reference.

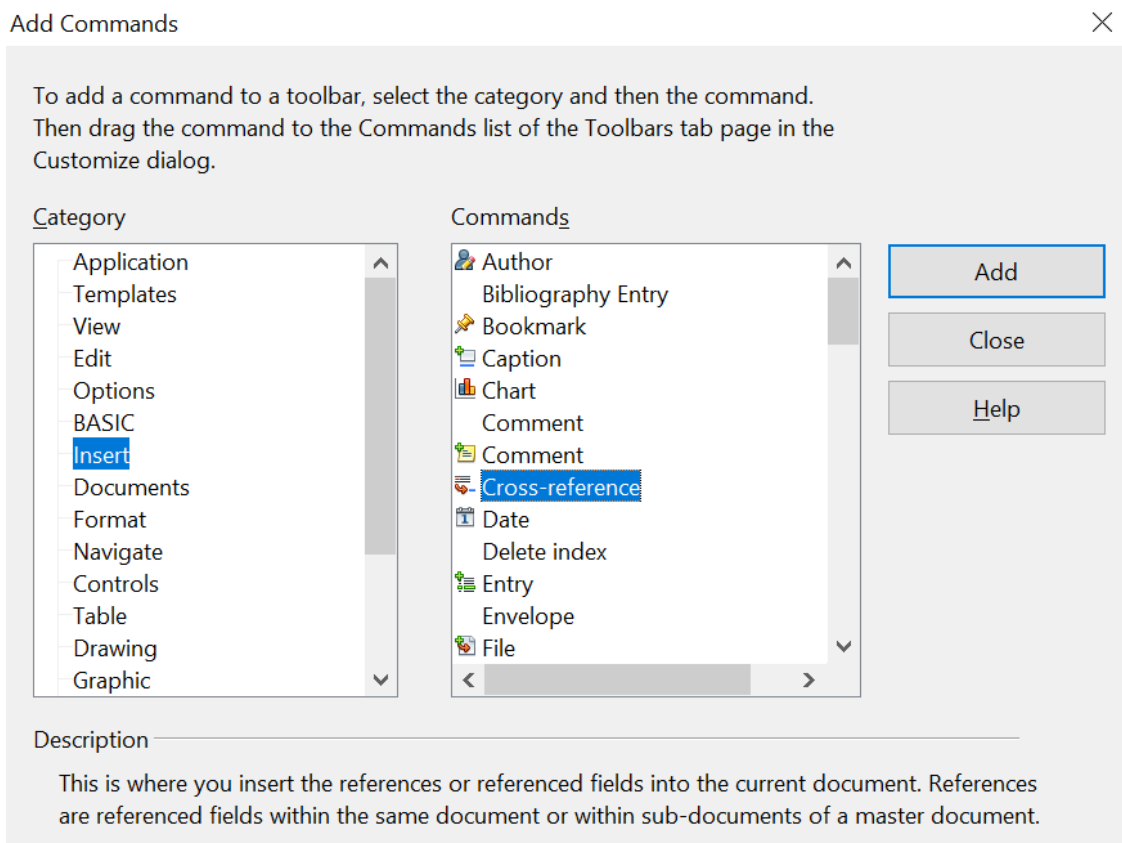
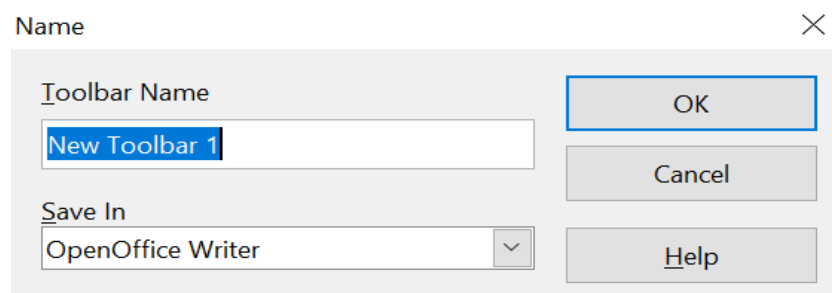


Figure 6: Adding a Cross-reference command to a toolbar

Creating a New Toolbar

To create a new toolbar:

- 1) Choose **Tools > Customize > Toolbars** from the menu bar.
- 2) Click **New**. On the Name dialog box, type the name for the new toolbar and choose, from the Save In drop-down list, the location where this changed menu will be stored, for the application (Writer) or for a selected document.



The new toolbar now appears on the list of toolbars in the Customize dialog box. After creating a new toolbar, you need to add some commands to it, as described above.

Assigning Shortcut Keys

In addition to using the built-in keyboard shortcuts (listed in Appendix A), you can define your own. You can assign shortcuts to standard functions or your own macros and save them for use with the entire OpenOffice suite.

Caution



Be very careful when reassigning your operating system's or OpenOffice's predefined shortcut keys. Many key assignments are universally understood shortcuts, such as *F1* for Help, and are always expected to provide certain results. Although you can easily reset the shortcut key assignments to the defaults, changing some common shortcut keys can cause confusion, frustration, and possible data loss or corruption, especially if other users share your computer.

To adapt shortcut keys to your needs, use the Customize dialog box, as described below.

- 1) Choose **Tools > Customize > Keyboard**. The Customize dialog box opens.
 - 2) To have the shortcut key assignment available in all components of OpenOffice, select the **OpenOffice** button.
 - 3) Next select the required function from the *Category* and *Function* lists.
 - 4) Now select the desired shortcut keys in the *Shortcut keys* list at the top of the tab and click the **Modify** button on the right. The selection now appears in the *Keys* list on the lower right.
 - 5) Click **OK** to accept the change. Now the chosen shortcut keys will execute the function chosen in step 3 above whenever they are pressed.
-

Note

All existing shortcut keys for the currently selected *Function* are listed in the *Keys* selection box. If the *Keys* list is empty, it indicates that the chosen key combination is free for use. If it were not, and you wanted to reassign a shortcut key combination that is already in use, you must first delete the existing key. If you do so, do it with caution.

Shortcut keys that are grayed-out in the listing on the Customize dialog box, such as *F1* and *F10*, are not available for reassignment.

Example: Assigning Styles to Shortcut Keys

You can configure shortcut keys to quickly assign styles in your document. Some shortcuts are predefined, such as *Ctrl+0* for the *Text body* paragraph style, *Ctrl+1* for the *Heading 1* style and *Ctrl+2* for *Heading 2*. You can modify these shortcuts and create your own.

- 1) Click **Tools > Customize > Keyboard**. The Keyboard tab of the Customize dialog box (Figure 7) opens.
- 2) To have the shortcut key assignment available only for Writer, select **Writer** in the upper right corner of the tab; otherwise select **OpenOffice** to make it available to every component.
- 3) Choose the shortcut keys you want to assign a style to. In this example, we have selected *Ctrl+9*.
- 4) In the *Functions* section at the bottom of the dialog box, scroll down in the *Category* list to *Styles*. Click the + sign to expand the list of styles.
- 5) Choose the category of style. (This example uses a paragraph style, but you can also choose character styles and others.) The *Function* list will display the names of the available styles for the selected category. The example shows some predefined styles.
- 6) To assign *Ctrl+9* to be the shortcut key combination for the List 1 style, select *List 1* in the *Function* list, and then click **Modify**. *Ctrl+9* now appears in the

Keys list on the right, and *List 1* appears next to *Ctrl+9* in the Shortcut keys box at the top.

- 7) Make any other required changes, and then click **OK** to save these settings and close the dialog box.

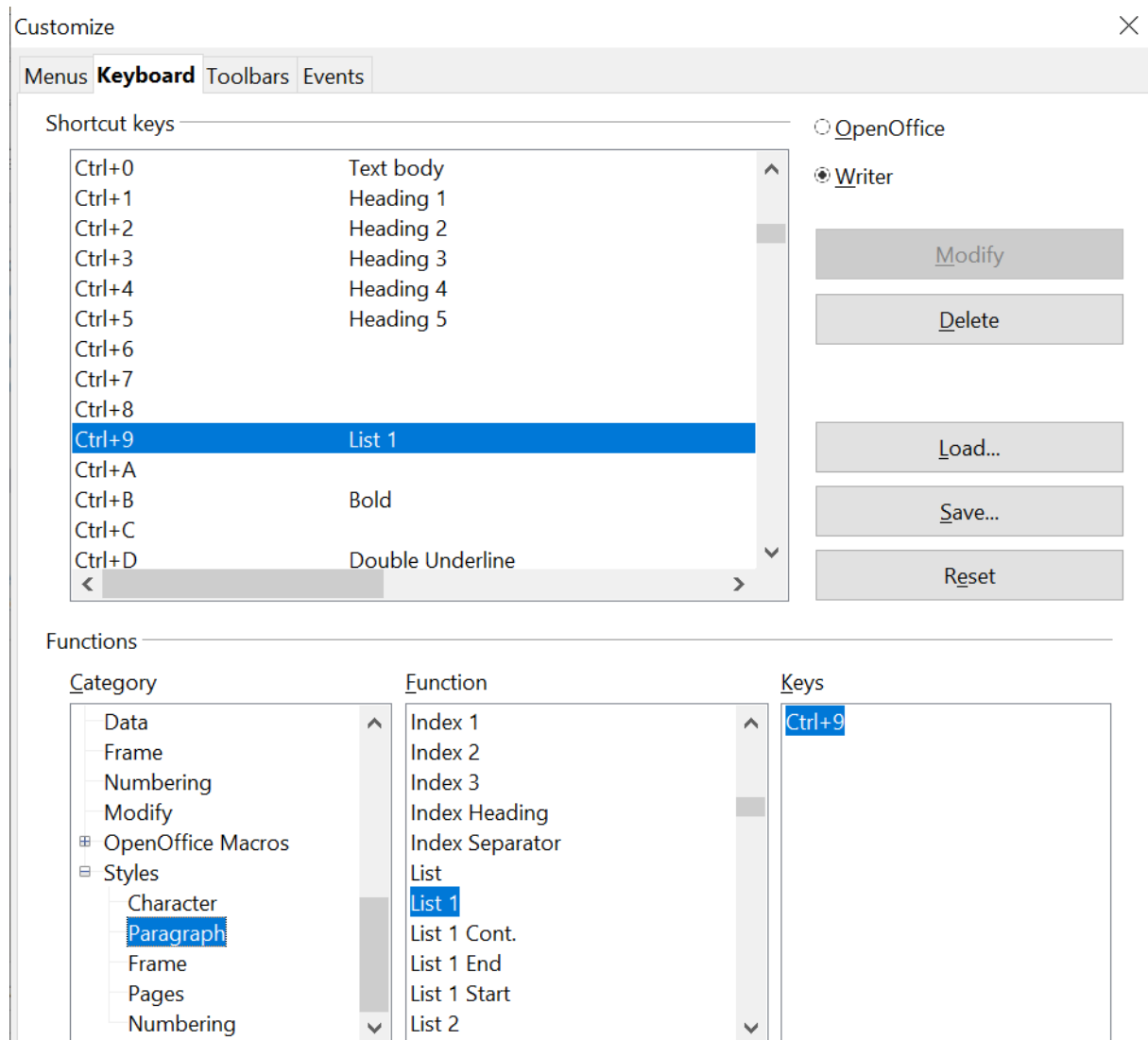


Figure 7. Defining keyboard shortcuts for applying styles

Example: Assigning Macros to Shortcut Keys

A common use for assigning macros to shortcut keys is to enable quick and easy insertion of special characters. This example shows how to set up keyboard shortcuts for inserting en dashes and em dashes. The en dash is approximately the length of the letter N, and the em dash the length of the letter M. The shorter en dash (–) is used to mark ranges and with the meaning “to” in phrases like “Dover–Calais crossing.” The longer em dash (—) is used to separate extra information or mark a break in a sentence.

First, you need to record a macro for inserting each type of dash. Then, you need to assign those macros to shortcut key combinations.

- 1) Choose **Tools > Macros > Record Macro** to start recording a macro.



A small window is displayed, so you know that OpenOffice is recording.

- 2) Choose **Insert > Special Characters** to open the Special Characters dialog box. Scroll down until you find the en dash (U+2013) and em dash (U+2014) characters. Select one of them and click **OK**.

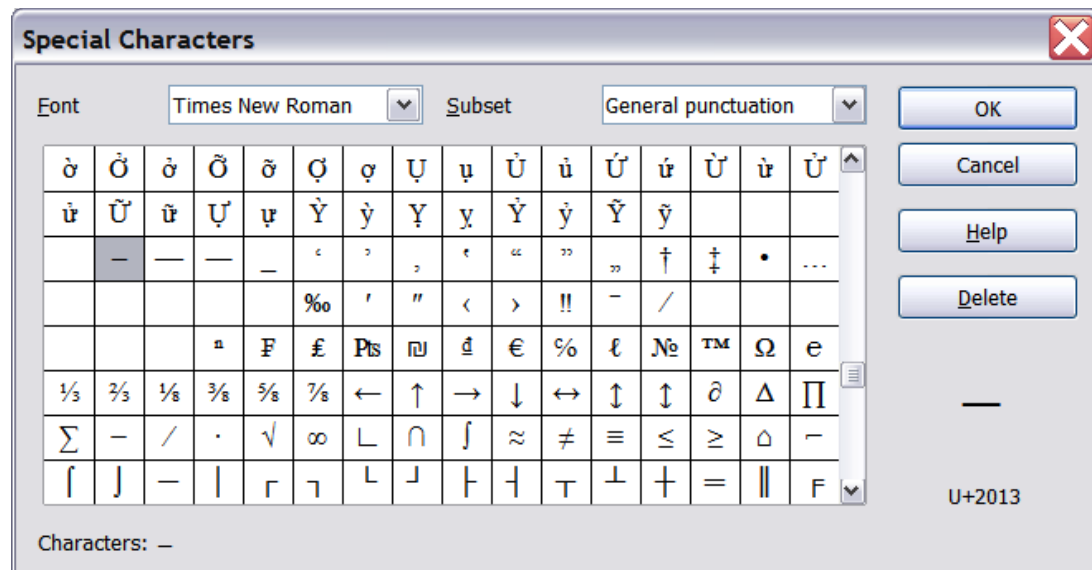


Figure 8: Find and choose the en dash.

- 3) Click the **Stop Recording** button to stop recording, save the macro, and display the OpenOffice Basic Macros dialog box (see Figure 9). Type a descriptive name for the new macro in the **Macro name** box on the upper left.

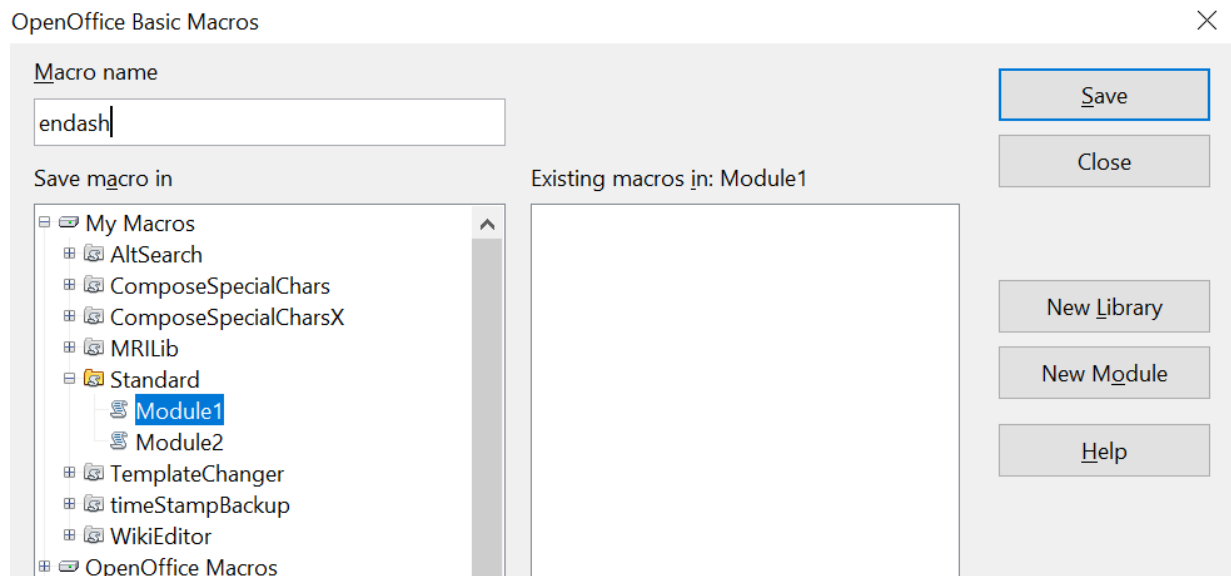


Figure 9: Naming the new macro and storing it

- 4) Be sure to open the library container named *My Macros*. Find the library named *Standard* under *My Macros*. Select *Module1* and click *Save*. The libraries listed under *My Macros* on your system will likely be different from those shown in the figure, but *Standard* will always be present.
- 5) Repeat steps 1–4 to create other macros, for example to insert an em dash.
- 6) Choose **Tools > Customize > Keyboard** tab (Figure 10). In the Shortcut keys list, pick an unused combination (for example, *Ctrl+Shift+N* for an en dash). In the Category list, scroll down to *OpenOffice Macros*, click the + sign (or small

triangle, depending on your operating system), then click the + (or triangle) next to *user* and then next to the *Standard* library and select *Module1*. In the Function list, pick **endash** and click the **Modify** button on the upper right. The selected key combination now appears in the Keys list on the lower right, and endash appears next to Ctrl+Shift+N in the Shortcut keys list.

7) Repeat for the em dash macro, then click **OK**.

Tip

For inserting en and em dashes, and other special characters, you may find extensions such as Compose Special Characters useful. See “Adding Functionality with Extensions” on page 15.

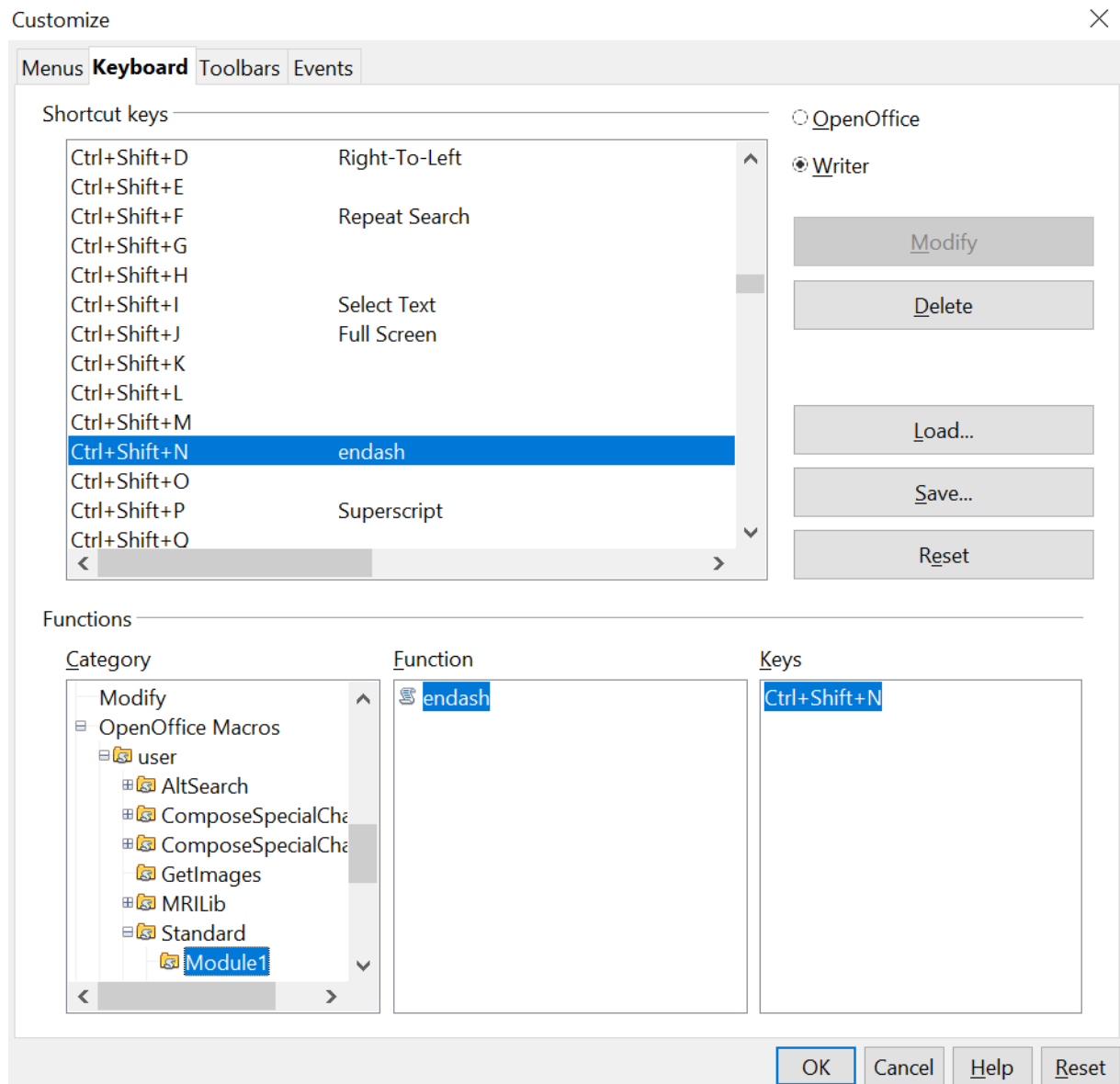


Figure 10: Defining keyboard shortcuts for running macros

Saving Changes to a File

Changes to the shortcut key assignments can be saved in a keyboard configuration file for use at a later time, thus permitting you to create and apply different configurations as the need arises. To save keyboard shortcuts to a file:

- 1) After making your keyboard shortcut assignments, click the **Save** button near the bottom right of the Customize dialog box (Figure 7).
- 2) In the Save Keyboard Configuration dialog box, select *All files* from the **Save as Type** list.
- 3) Next enter a name for the keyboard configuration file in the **File name** box, or select an existing file from the list. If you need to, browse to find a file from another location.
- 4) Click **Save**. A confirmation dialog box appears if you are about to overwrite an existing file, otherwise there will be no feedback and the file will be saved.

Loading a Saved Keyboard Configuration

To load a saved keyboard configuration file and replace your existing configuration, click the **Load** button near the bottom right of the Customize dialog box, and then select the configuration file from the Load Keyboard Configuration dialog box.

Resetting the Shortcut Keys

To reset all the keyboard shortcuts to their default values, click the **Reset** button near the bottom right of the Customize dialog box. Use this feature with care as no confirmation dialog box will be displayed; the defaults will be set without any further notice or user input.

Assigning Macros to Events

In OpenOffice, when something happens, we say that an event occurred. For example, a document was opened, a key was pressed, or the mouse moved. You can associate a macro with an event, so the macro is run when the event occurs. For example, a common use is to assign the “open document” event to run a macro that performs certain setup tasks for the document. To associate a macro with an event, use the Events tab of the Customize dialog box.

Adding Functionality with Extensions

An extension is a package that can be installed into OpenOffice to add new functionality.

Although individual extensions can be found in different places, the official OpenOffice extension repository is at <https://extensions.openoffice.org/>. Most extensions are free of charge; others are available for a fee. Check the descriptions to see what licenses and fees apply to the ones that interest you.

Installing Extensions

To install an extension, follow these steps:

- 1) Download an extension and save it anywhere on your computer.
- 2) In OpenOffice, select **Tools > Extension Manager** from the menu bar. In the Extension Manager dialog box (Figure 11), click **Add**.

- 3) A file browser window opens. Find and select the extension you want to install and click **Open**. The extension begins installing. You may be asked to accept a license agreement.
- 4) When the installation is complete, the extension is listed in the Extension Manager dialog box.

Tip

To get extensions that are listed in the repository, you can open the Extension Manager and click the **Get more extensions online** link. You do not need to download them separately as in step 1 above.

Note

To install a *shared* extension, you need to have write access to the OpenOffice installation directory. That is, you must have access permissions that allow you to add to or delete from the directory (folder) where OpenOffice has been installed.

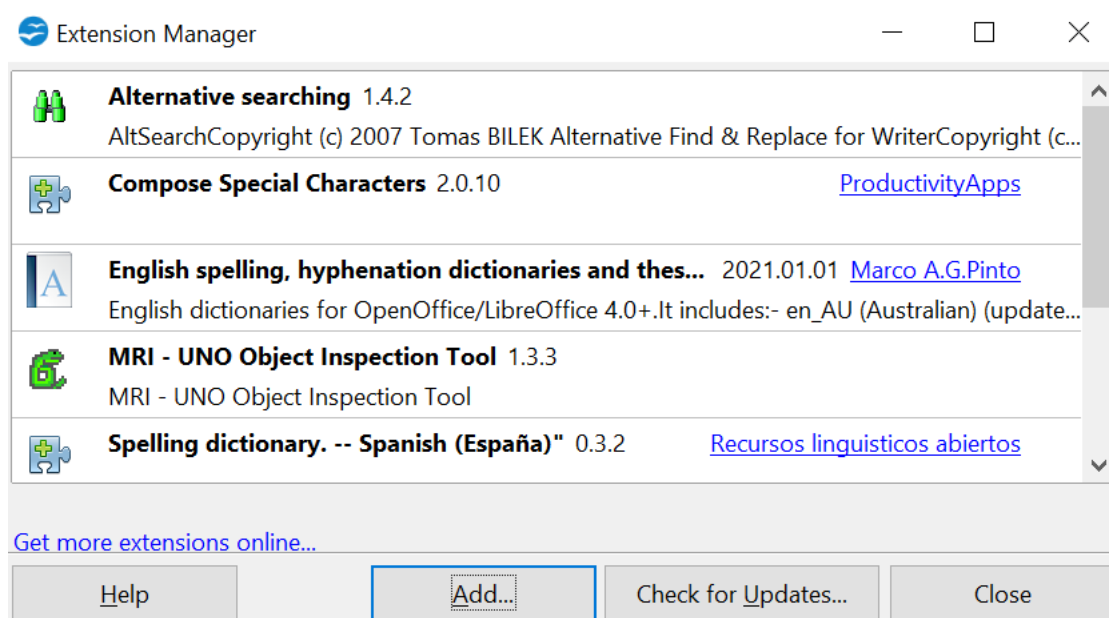


Figure 11: Using the Extension Manager

Using Extensions

This section describes a few of the more important and popular extensions to Writer. All are available from the AOO extensions repository. In each case, you need to first install the extension as described in the previous section.

Template Changer

Adds two new items to the **File > Templates** menu that allow you to assign a new template to the current document or to a folder of documents. All styles and formatting will be loaded from that template and the document will behave as if it was created using that template. Open source.

Compose Special Characters

Provides a facility for inserting accented and special characters using key combinations. Adds an entry (**Compose Character**) to the **Insert** menu, which opens a dialog box where you can view the list of key combinations and choose the keystroke you want to use to run the macro. Once setup is done, simply press the appropriate key combination, followed by the keystroke to run the macro. Open source.

Professional Template Pack II

Provides more than 120 templates for Writer, Calc, and Impress. Available in several languages. After you have installed this extension, you will find the templates under **File > New > Templates and Documents**. From Oracle. Freeware.

PDF Import for Apache OpenOffice

This extension enables you to make minor modifications to the text of existing PDF files when the original source files do not exist, or you are unable to open the source files. (Whenever possible, modify the source and regenerate the PDF to obtain the best results.)

When the extension is installed, PDF is listed as a choice in the File Type drop-down list in the **File > Open** dialog box.

Best results can be achieved with the *PDF/ODF hybrid file* format, which this extension also enables. A hybrid PDF/ODF file is a PDF file that contains an embedded ODF source file. Hybrid PDF/ODF files will be opened in OpenOffice as an ODF file without any layout changes.

Non-hybrid PDF documents open in Draw. Many PDFs can be edited and resaved with no problems. However, depending on the complexity of the layout, the fonts used, the graphics included, and other factors, changes may be difficult to make, font substitution may occur, and the saved result may not preserve the original layout.